lay-off. Chinaman Kuldeep Yadav, the man-of-the-tournament at the Asia Cup, has the entire cricket world scratching their heads, trying to figure out his wrong 'un. And the ever exuberant Mohammed Siraj, with his wobbled seam and extra bounce, has had hapless opposition batters flailing around (his six-fer in the Asia Cup final was a testament to that).

**IFTIKHAR AHMED**
**PAKISTAN**
Beyond the prowess of Babar Azam and Shaheen Afridi, in Iftikhar, Pakistan has a player who has delivered under pressure, both with the bat and with his slow off-spin



AFP

## DRY AS DUST

***The Men in Blue haven't won a top ICC trophy in a decade, the last being the 2013 Champions Trophy***

**2014**
**T20 WORLD CUP**
HOST: Bangladesh
Finish: Runners-up
Winner: **SRI LANKA**

**2016**
**T20 WORLD CUP**
HOST: India
Finish: Semi-finals
Winner: **WEST INDIES**

**2017**
**CHAMPIONS TROPHY**
HOST: England & Wales
Finish: Runners-up
Winner: **PAKISTAN**

**2021**
**WORLD TEST CHAMPIONSHIP**
Finish: Runners-up
Winner: **NEW ZEALAND**

**2021**
**T20 WORLD CUP**
HOST: UAE & Oman
Finish: Group stage
Winner: **AUSTRALIA**

**2022**
**T20 WORLD CUP**
HOST: Australia
Finish: Semi-finals
Winner: **ENGLAND**

**2023**
**ICC WORLD TEST CHAMPIONSHIP**
Finish: Runners-up
Winner: **AUSTRALIA**

From not knowing what their ideal XI was just about a month ago, to becoming the 'idol XI' of ODI cricket has marked quite a dramatic turnaround for this Indian team. It's this assortment of match-winners that has allowed India to win handsomely in recent one-dayers, including the three-match series against Australia that saw a rearguard fightback by the middle-order pair of K.L. Rahul and Surya Kumar Yadav to seal the first ODI and a Gill-Iyer blitzkrieg that took India to a record total of 399 in the second. Quite clearly, this multi-pronged attack could be the X factor if India is to land the biggest prize in cricket.

### CHINKS IN THE ARMOUR

But work through the sturdy Indian exterior and examine the finer details and some cracks begin to appear in the arsenal. The lack of all-rounders, for one. Much like today's corporate workplace where multi-tasking is the buzzword, multi-dimensional players have become a necessity in cricket; more so in one-day cricket where the premium is on bowlers contributing with the bat and vice versa. This was also India's secret sauce during the 2011 World Cup as the likes of Yuvraj Singh, Suresh Raina and Irfan Pathan—all proper batters—chipped in with vital break-